



“ HE’LL HAVE US GOING TO THE MOON YET. ”

Great Western Railway director, on Isambard Kingdom Brunel

using dots and dashes. Morse’s telegraph was far simpler than the Cooke Wheatstone design, and soon became the standard instrument worldwide, revolutionizing the global movement of information.

When Britain’s King William IV died on 20 June, he had no surviving legitimate heir, so the crown passed to **Victoria**, his niece (see panel, below). She was the daughter of Edward, Duke of Kent, and granddaughter of George III. Her reign was viewed as a time of growing prosperity, technological innovation, and colonial expansion.

In **Japan**, **Tokugawa Ieyoshi** (1793–1853) became shogun. At the time of his rule Japan was experiencing social and economic decline. He introduced measures known as the **Tempo Reforms**, restricting migration to urban areas and instigating price controls—but they failed.

QUEEN VICTORIA (1819–1901)

Ruling for 63 years and 216 days, Queen Victoria remains the longest-reigning monarch of Britain. In 1840, she married her cousin, Albert of Saxe-Coburg and Gotha (1819–61). She adored him and they had nine children together. The Victorian era contrasted sharply with the excesses of previous Hanoverian rulers, and Victoria’s domestic life was held up as the model for families in this period.



TRANSPORTATION TECHNOLOGY

was rapidly changing. Along with the expansion in rail transport, travel by sea was also being revolutionized by many innovations. The power of steam was finally harnessed in an efficient way that allowed for much quicker sea crossings (see 1786). On 8 April 1838, the **Great Western** left Bristol for its maiden transatlantic voyage, and

Brunel’s Great Western

The Great Western steamship shown off the west coast of England. The sails helped to propel the ship and keep it on an even keel.

arrived in New York 15 days later; the paddle-wheeled steamship had cut the voyage time in half and arrived with fuel to spare. The ship had been designed by leading British civil engineer **Isambard Kingdom Brunel** (1806–59), who had also been involved in other engineering projects, including the Great Western Railway. The idea for the steamship started as a suggestion by Brunel to Great Western Railway directors that the train line could be extended to New York by way of a regular transatlantic service. Soon after, the **Great Western Steamship Company** was set up to facilitate the construction of the ship.

In the Americas, **Guatemala**, **Honduras**, and **Nicaragua** became independent nations.



The East India Company’s steamer, *Nemesis*, attacks Chinese war junks in Anson’s Bay, at the mouth of the Pearl River, China, during the First Opium War.

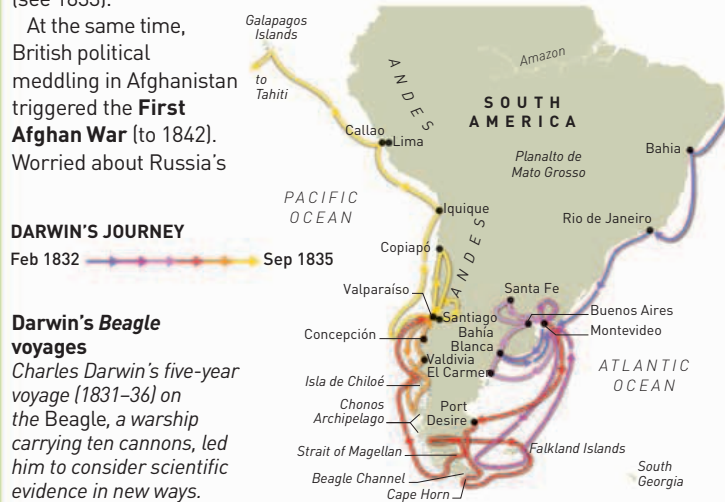
WHILE BRITISH TRADE IN CHINA CONTINUED TO EXPAND, so too did the Chinese opium problem. Decades earlier, the East India Company had started exporting the drug, produced from **poppies** grown in Bengal, to China in order to trade it for tea, which it then sent to Britain. Despite numerous attempts to ban the importation of the substance, British ships continued to import it. On March 30, 1839, one frustrated Chinese commissioner ordered British warehouses and ships in Canton to be destroyed. Britain sent warships in retaliation, attacking China’s coastline in the **First Opium War**.

Meanwhile, tensions between Egypt and the Ottoman sultan erupted again in the **Second Turko–Egyptian War**. This time it was triggered by an Ottoman attempt to invade Syria, which it had previously ceded to Egypt (see 1833).

At the same time, British political meddling in Afghanistan triggered the **First Afghan War** (to 1842). Worried about Russia’s

growing influence over the Afghan emir, **Dost Muhammad Khan** (1793–1863), Britain attempted to replace him with an emir more sympathetic to British interests in northern India, including the protection of overland trade routes through the region.

In England, naturalist Charles Darwin (see 1835) published an account of the diary he kept while on the *Beagle*. The journey had taken Darwin around the world. He had set off from Plymouth in 1831 for the Cape Verde Islands, then Brazil, Argentina, Uruguay, and Tierra del Fuego. He then sailed north along the Pacific Coast of South America, stopping at the Galápagos Islands, before going onward to Tahiti, New Zealand, Australia, Mauritius, and finally back to England, arriving in October 1836. Darwin’s account helped make his name in science.



Darwin’s Beagle voyages

Charles Darwin’s five-year voyage (1831–36) on the *Beagle*, a warship carrying ten cannons, led him to consider scientific evidence in new ways.

June 20 Victoria (1819–1901) becomes British monarch

Upper Canada and Lower Canada rebellions against British rule are put down

September 28 Akbar Shah II, last Mughal emperor of India dies (b. 1760)

Louis Daguerre develops the daguerreotype, a photographic process

Chartist movement begins to form, calling for social reform in Britain

Guatemala, Honduras, and Nicaragua become independent

May 26 Cherokee tribe forcibly relocated in US in the **Trail of Tears**

Proteins discovered by Swedish chemist, **Jöns Jakob Berzelius** (1779–1848)

June 10 **Myall Creek Massacre**, Australia, in which 28 Aborigines killed by settlers

December 16 **Battle of Blood River**, South Africa, in which **Boers** win victory over **Zulus**

First Anglo-Afghan War (to 1842) over British attempts to topple Afghanistan’s emir

English naturalist **Charles Darwin** publishes diary of the voyage of the *Beagle*

November 3 **First Opium War** begins between Britain and China (to 1842) over trade and access to ports in China

Abdul Mejid I (1823–61) becomes Ottoman sultan

British occupy Arabian port of **Aden** to prevent pirate attacks on shipping to India